Anger Management Toolbox

FIVE MYTHS ABOUT ANGER

MYTH	TRUTH
Hitting a pillow or punching bag gets the anger out.	It feels good for a moment, but it trains your brain to link anger with hitting. Calming your body works better.
If I don't tell people off, they'll walk all over me.	You can stand up for yourself calmly. Calm and clear comes across as strong.
Holding back what I think in the moment is dishonest.	Anger clouds judgment, so words said in anger often aim to hurt, not to explain. Waiting until you're calm lets you say what you actually mean.
Anger is a bad emotion.	Anger is a normal feeling. It can warn you that something is wrong and give you energy to fix it. What you do with it is what matters.
I can't control my anger.	Anger builds in stages, and you can step in at each one. Like any skill, it gets easier with practice.

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10 RULES FOR FAIR FIGHTING

The goal is resolution, not victory.

1. **No name-calling.**
   Attack the problem, not the person.

2. **No bringing up the past.**
   Stay focused on the current issue.

3. **No yelling or intimidation.**
   Keep your voice calm and level.

4. **Take turns speaking.**
   Listen as much as you talk.

5. **Take a timeout if needed.**
   Walk away, cool down, come back.

6. **Use "I" statements.**
   "I feel..." instead of "You always..."

7. **No threats or ultimatums.**
   Seek resolution, not surrender.

8. **Be willing to compromise.**
   Winning is less important than resolving.

9. **Acknowledge feelings.**
   Validate the other person's emotions.

10. **End with a plan.**
    Agree on next steps before parting.

MAKING A TIMEOUT PLAN

Agree on a signal that means "timeout." Agree on how long: long enough to calm down, usually 20 minutes to an hour. Do something calming, not something that adds fuel. Come back and finish the conversation.

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Physical Techniques

- **Deep breathing:** Inhale for 4 counts, hold 4, exhale 8. Repeat until calm.
- **Progressive muscle relaxation:** Tense and release each muscle group, head to toe.
- **Physical exercise:** Walk, run, or stretch to burn off adrenaline and cortisol.

Mental Techniques

- **Cognitive reframing:** Challenge angry thoughts. Is there another explanation?
- **Counting to ten:** Simple but effective — gives your rational brain time to catch up.
- **Visualization:** Picture a calm place or a positive outcome to the situation.

Social Techniques

- **Talk it out:** Share your feelings with a trusted friend, family member, or counselor.
- **Use humor:** Lighten the mood (without sarcasm) to defuse tension.
- **Set boundaries:** Remove yourself from toxic situations or relationships when needed.

Mindfulness Techniques

- **Grounding (5-4-3-2-1):** Name 5 things you see, 4 you touch, 3 you hear, 2 you smell, 1 you taste.
- **Journaling:** Write down your feelings to process and release them.
- **Meditation:** Even 5 minutes of focused breathing can reset your emotional state.

THINGS TO SAY TO YOURSELF

"This will pass."

"I don't have to answer right now."

"I can handle this."

"I'll come back to this when I'm calm."

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MY ANGER THERMOMETER

Name: _____ **Date:** _____



Boiling

clenched fists, can't hear the other person

My warning signs: _____

_____

What I will do: _____

_____

Rising

louder voice, racing heart, pacing

My warning signs: _____

_____

What I will do: _____

_____

Early

tight jaw, warm face, shorter answers

My warning signs: _____

_____

What I will do: _____

_____

MY TIMEOUT PLAN

My signal: _____ **How long:** _____

What I'll do to calm down: _____ **Who I can talk to:** _____

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